

A-Level Business: Evaluation

Which sentence earns which mark. AQA 7132 and Edexcel 9BS0.

The editable Word version is included in this download. Every lesson, all three annotated model answers, the mid band rewrite and every table are ordinary Word text. Change the business, swap a question, cut a task, or adapt the annotations to your own mark scheme. A PowerPoint version of the four lessons is in the same download.

What this pack is

The evaluation skill, taught properly. Four complete lessons with timings and full answers, three model answers in which every single sentence is marked with what it earns and why, a mid band answer improved in front of the class, a checklist of what actually earns evaluation marks, and the fourteen errors that cost students the most. It is written to be taught as it stands.

The thing that makes it different

Most model answers are handed out whole and students are told they are good. That teaches very little, because the student cannot see which part did the work. In this pack every model answer is broken into numbered sentences, and each sentence carries a tag saying what it earns, plus a line saying why. Students can see which sentences earn nothing, which one carries the calculation, and which single sentence lifts the whole answer into the top band.

It is editable

Three formats. The PDF is for printing. The Word file contains every lesson, every model answer, every annotation and all answers as ordinary editable text, so you can change the business, cut a task, or rewrite a question for your own class. The PowerPoint contains the slides for all four lessons. Nothing is an image and nothing is locked.

Who it is for

Teachers of A-Level Business on AQA 7132 or Edexcel 9BS0, teaching Year 12 or Year 13. Both boards are covered. The two long model answers are written to the question styles of each board, and they use the same business, so students carry the context across and spend their attention on the skill rather than on a new case.

The diagnosis, in one paragraph

Students lose evaluation marks for a small number of repeatable reasons. They write balance instead of judgement, so the answer has two sides and no decision. They decide, but from nothing, so the judgement floats free of the evidence. They evaluate the theory rather than the business. They save the judgement for a final paragraph that runs out of time. Every one of those is a habit, and habits are teachable in four lessons.

A note on accuracy

Mark schemes, level descriptors and tariffs change, and they differ between boards. This pack teaches what an evaluative sentence has to do, using the four assessment objectives that both boards share. It does not quote level descriptors and it does not claim which paper carries which tariff. Take those from your current specification and mark schemes, which are free and current. Verity Coffee is a constructed business, so every figure is internally consistent and any calculation in the models can be checked with a calculator.

The method, in five steps

Step	What it means and why it earns
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1. Decide before you write.	Read the question, then write your answer to it in one sentence at the top of the page. If you cannot, you are not ready to write. Students who decide at the end run out of time and staple a conclusion onto an answer that argued the other way.
2. Pick the criterion.	Better or worse is meaningless on its own. Better or worse for what this business is trying to do right now is a judgement. Name the criterion in the first paragraph: protecting cash, defending a market position, lifting margin, surviving the next twelve months.
3. Build the strongest version of the case you are going to reject.	An answer that only argues one way is not evaluation, it is advocacy. Put the other side at its strongest, using the business's own figures, then show why it does not hold here. Rejecting a strong argument earns more than beating a weak one.
4. Weigh with a number.	Evaluation without evidence is opinion. The sentence that turns a judgement into a mark almost always contains a figure from the case, a comparison, or a magnitude. Six years is a long payback carries weight. This might not work does not.
5. Attach the condition.	End by naming what would change your mind. It takes one sentence, most students never write it, and it is one of the cheapest ways to lift an answer.

The four assessment objectives

	Name	What it is	The test
AO1	Knowledge	A term used correctly, a concept named, a formula stated.	Necessary, and cheap. It is the floor of an answer, never the ceiling. A whole paragraph of AO1 earns very little.
AO2	Application	The point is tied to this business, using its figures, its market or its situation.	The test is simple. If the sentence would be equally true of a different company, it is not application.
AO3	Analysis	A consequence followed through. Because this, therefore that, which means this for the business.	One developed chain beats three assertions. Analysis is where most of the middle of an answer lives.
AO4	Evaluation	A judgement, a weighing of one thing against another, a condition, or a supported decision.	This is the objective students avoid, and the one that separates grades. It is a way of writing, not a final paragraph.

What actually earns the evaluation mark

Check	What good looks like	What it catches
Does the answer decide?	A decision stated clearly, not a summary of both sides.	It depends, both have advantages, and in conclusion it is important to consider all factors are the three phrases that mark an answer as undecided.
Is the decision supported?	At least one figure, comparison or piece of case evidence sits behind the judgement.	A judgement with nothing behind it reads as a guess, however confident the wording.
Is there a criterion?	The answer says better for what, not just better.	Without a criterion there is nothing to weigh against, so the weighing cannot happen.
Is the other side taken seriously?	The rejected argument appears at its strongest before it is rejected.	Knocking down a weak version of the opposing case is the most common way to lose evaluation marks while appearing to evaluate.
Is the judgement about this business?	The reasoning uses this firm's position, not businesses in general.	If the paragraph would survive being pasted into an answer about a different company, it is not evaluative about this one.
Is there a condition?	The answer names what would change the decision.	One sentence. It shows the judgement is reasoned rather than picked.
Is evaluation spread through the answer?	Judgement appears in more than the final paragraph.	Evaluation saved for the end is evaluation that runs out of time. The strongest answers weigh as they go.
Is anything being said that earns nothing?	Sentences that restate the question or announce what the answer will do.	In this essay I will discuss costs a mark and buys nothing. Cut it and start with the

		decision.
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The tag key

Tag	Objective	What it means
K	Knowledge, AO1	A term used correctly or a concept named. Necessary, cheap, and never enough on its own.
AP	Application, AO2	Tied to this business using its figures or its situation. If it would be true of another company, it is not application.
AN	Analysis, AO3	A consequence followed through. Because this, therefore that, which means this here.
EV	Evaluation, AO4	A judgement, a weighing, a condition, or a supported decision.
0	Earns nothing	Restating the question, announcing what the essay will do, or a sentence true of any business anywhere.

Verity Coffee

Verity Coffee is a UK coffee shop chain with 120 sites, mostly on high streets and in retail parks. It sells coffee, cold drinks and a small food range. Over the last two years revenue has grown but profitability has not kept pace, and the board has asked for options.

	Year ended 2025	Year ended 2024
Revenue	£96.0m	£88.0m
Operating profit	£4.8m	£7.92m
Operating profit margin	5.0 per cent	9.0 per cent
Number of sites	120	118
Average revenue per site	£0.80m	£0.75m

Option one, close the 20 weakest sites

	Figure
Combined revenue of the 20 weakest sites	£9.6m
Average revenue of those 20 sites	£0.48m
Combined operating loss of those 20 sites	£0.6m
Estimated cost of closing a site, average	£180,000
Unexpired leases on those sites	Between 2 and 9 years

Option two, a coffee subscription

	Figure
Proposed subscription price	£15 per month, unlimited filter coffee
Filter coffee selling price	£3.20
Filter coffee cost to make	£0.35
Average food item price	£4.10
Gross margin on food	65 per cent
Average visits per month, current customer	6
Average visits per month during the subscription trial	11

Verity Coffee is constructed. Every figure is internally consistent, so any calculation quoted in the model answers can be checked with a calculator and it will agree.

Question 1, 25 marks

To what extent should Verity Coffee respond to its falling margin by closing its 20 weakest sites? Justify your view.

AQA 7132 style. A single extended question with a judgement required throughout.

Question 2, 20 marks

Evaluate the likely impact on Verity Coffee of introducing the proposed coffee subscription scheme.

Edexcel 9BS0 style. Same business, so students carry the context and spend their attention on the skill.

Model answer 1, annotated

#	The sentence	Tag	What it earns and why
1	Verity Coffee's operating margin has fallen from 9.0 per cent to 5.0 per cent in a single year, so the pressure to act is real rather than imagined.	K + AP	Two figures from the case, used to establish that the problem is genuine. Opening with evidence rather than with a definition is worth copying.
2	Closing the 20 weakest sites would remove a combined operating loss of £0.6 million, which on its own would lift group operating profit from £4.8 million to £5.4 million.	AP + AN	The figure is applied and then followed through to its effect on the group. This is the case for closure stated properly, not vaguely.
3	Because revenue would fall by £9.6 million at the same time, margin would rise from 5.0 per cent to about 6.3 per cent, so the ratio improves even though the business gets smaller.	AP + AN	A second step in the same chain, and a genuine insight. Most students stop after the profit effect and miss that the margin improves partly because the denominator shrinks.
4	That is the case for closure at its strongest, and all of it rests on the £0.6 million being a saving that recurs every year.	AP + EV	Sets up the counter argument and names the assumption holding it up, in one sentence. Signposting on its own earns nothing, which is why this sentence carries a condition as well.
5	It fails on the cost of getting out, which is why Verity should not close them.	EV	The decision, in sentence 5. Deciding early costs nothing and it organises everything that follows. Short sentences carry evaluation perfectly well.
6	At an average of £180,000 per site the closures cost £3.6 million, which is six times the annual loss being removed.	AP + AN	The calculation is done, and then converted into a comparison. The comparison is what makes it evaluative rather than arithmetical.
7	So the payback on closing these sites is six years, and that is before any lease that cannot be exited early.	K + AN + EV	The single strongest sentence in the answer. It turns two figures into a number a board would act on, and then flags a risk that makes it worse.
8	A business whose margin has fallen by more than 40 per cent in one year is unlikely to have six years of patience.	EV	Weighing against a criterion, which here is the time the business actually has. This is what better or worse for what looks like in practice.
9	Weak revenue is not the same thing as weak contribution, and the case gives revenue only.	K + EV	Challenges the quality of the evidence rather than adding another point. Interrogating the data you have been given is the kind of move that separates answers at the top.
10	The 20 sites average £0.48 million of revenue against a chain average of £0.80 million, which makes them weak, but weak is not the same as loss making at the margin.	AP + EV	A precise distinction, drawn from the figures. Recognising that a category in the question may be the wrong category is a high level move.
11	If most of their cost base is fixed rent that continues after closure, shutting them removes the revenue and keeps the cost.	K + AN	A conditional consequence. Conditional reasoning belongs in the body of the answer, not only in the conclusion.
12	Verity's real problem is margin, and margin has fallen across the whole estate rather than in 20 places.	EV	Reframing the question. This is the point at which the answer stops accepting the premise it was handed, which is where the top band starts.
13	Revenue grew about 9 per cent while operating profit fell by nearly 40 per cent, which points to cost inflation or discounting across all 120 sites rather than to 20 bad locations.	AP + AN	Two calculations from the case supporting the reframe. Notice the judgement in sentence 12 came first and the evidence follows immediately. Either order works, but they must be adjacent.
14	Closing 20 sites would therefore treat the symptom that is easiest to see rather than the one doing the damage.	EV	The judgement stated in a form a decision maker would recognise. No new evidence, and none needed, because sentence 13 supplied it.
15	On balance the answer stands: Verity should not close the 20 sites now.	EV	Restating a decision made in sentence 5 would earn little on its own. What earns here is the word now, which

			converts a permanent verdict into one about timing, and timing is what sentences 17 and 18 then resolve.
16	It should first establish how much of each site's cost base actually disappears on closure, because that single number decides whether the £3.6 million buys anything at all.	EV	A next step that is proportionate to the risk. This is what justify your view asks for beyond the decision itself.
17	If a material share of the cost is unavoidable lease commitment, closure destroys value and the answer is a firm no.	EV	The condition, first branch. This is the sentence most students never write.
18	If the leases are short and genuinely exitable, the six year payback becomes perhaps two, and closure becomes the right call as part of a wider attack on cost across the whole estate.	EV	The condition, second branch. Naming both branches shows the judgement was reasoned rather than picked, and it costs two sentences.

Eighteen sentences. Four carry knowledge, seven carry application, six carry analysis, twelve carry evaluation, and none earn nothing. The answer decides in sentence 5, before a third of it has been written, and then spends the rest earning the right to that decision. That distribution is the point of the page. Ask students to run the same count on their own last essay.

Model answer 2, annotated

#	The sentence	Tag	What it earns and why
1	The scheme cannibalises existing sales: it replaces £19.20 of monthly coffee revenue from an average customer with a flat £15, so before anything else happens Verity gives up £4.20 a month per subscriber.	K + AP + AN	Names the concept, then quantifies it. Six visits at £3.20 is the calculation, and it is done rather than described. Cannibalisation is the AO1 term this question is built on and most answers never use it.
2	The trial suggests that is not the whole story, because subscribers visited 11 times a month against a normal 6.	AP	The counter evidence introduced immediately, so the answer is weighing from the second sentence rather than after a page.
3	Those extra visits cost almost nothing to serve, because at £0.35 a cup 11 visits cost Verity £3.85.	AP + AN	The consequence of the cost structure, not just the cost. Low variable cost is the reason a subscription can work at all here.
4	The scheme only becomes loss making on coffee cost alone at about 43 visits a month, which no customer will reach.	AN + EV	A calculated boundary, £15 divided by £0.35. Working out where a proposal would actually fail, and showing it is nowhere near, is a strong evaluative move and almost nobody does it.
5	So the risk is not the cost of the coffee but the revenue the customer used to pay, and on the trial numbers that is enough to make the scheme marginal at best.	EV	Rejects the obvious objection, names the real one, and reaches a position, all in sentence 5. Deciding early organises everything that follows.
6	On the trial numbers coffee contribution per customer falls from £17.10 a month to £11.15, a loss of £5.95.	K + AP + AN	The full chain, quantified. Contribution rather than revenue, which is the correct measure for this decision.
7	Food is where that £5.95 has to come back.	AN	Nine words, and the figure is what keeps it from being pure signposting. Even so this is analysis rather than judgement: it directs the answer and names the mechanism, but it does not yet weigh anything. Signposting with no content in it earns nothing at all.
8	At £4.10 and a 65 per cent gross margin each food item contributes about £2.67, so the scheme needs roughly 2.2 extra food purchases per subscriber per month simply to stand still.	K + AP + AN	The decisive calculation of the whole answer. It converts a vague hope about attachment into a testable number.
9	That is a demanding target, because it asks five extra visits to produce two	AN + EV	Converts the number into a judgement about difficulty. The magnitude is what makes this evaluative rather than

	extra food sales.		descriptive.
10	It is not out of reach, though: a customer in the shop 11 times a month rather than 6 has more chances to buy, and the food range is small enough that widening it is within Verity's control.	EV	The other side, taken seriously and tied to something the business can actually do. Balance that is anchored in the case rather than in generalities.
11	Subscriptions also attract the heaviest users first, so the early trial numbers will look worse than the eventual average once lighter customers join.	EV	Challenges the reliability of the evidence the answer has been using. Interrogating your own data is a top band habit.
12	None of this touches the underlying problem, which is that operating margin has fallen from 9.0 to 5.0 per cent across all 120 sites while a subscription changes the mix of revenue rather than the cost base.	AP + EV	Places the proposal against the business's actual problem. This is weighing against a criterion in its clearest form.
13	The likely impact is therefore a small negative in year one, turning positive only if food attachment rises by more than about two items per subscriber per month.	EV	The decision, with the condition built into the same sentence. Evaluate asks for exactly this.
14	Verity should extend the trial and measure one number, food items per visit, because that number decides the outcome and nothing else in the proposal does.	EV	A proportionate next step. Naming the single measure that settles the question is stronger than recommending more analysis in general.

Fourteen sentences. Three carry knowledge, six carry application, seven carry analysis, eight carry evaluation, and none earn nothing. The answer reaches a position in sentence 5. Notice how much of the evaluation is carried by short sentences, and that the two decisive lines are among the shortest on the page. Length is not the variable students should be adjusting.

Model answer 3, the short one

#	The sentence	Tag	What it earns and why
1	Verity should not close the 20 sites yet.	EV	The decision, in the first line and in eight words. Nothing is lost by deciding early and a great deal is gained, and the word yet carries the timing argument that sentences 5 and 6 resolve.
2	Closing them removes a £0.6 million loss but costs £3.6 million, which is a six year payback for a business whose margin has fallen by more than 40 per cent in a year.	K + AP + AN + EV	One sentence carrying four objectives at once, which is what efficient writing under time pressure produces.
3	The weak sites are also the wrong target: revenue grew 9 per cent while operating profit fell nearly 40 per cent, which is an estate wide cost problem, not twenty bad locations.	AP + AN + EV	The reframe, evidenced, in a single sentence rather than the paragraph the long version uses.
4	Closure would improve margin to about 6.3 per cent on paper, so the number would look better while the cause went untreated.	AP + AN + EV	Concedes the strongest counter argument and disposes of it in the same sentence.
5	The figure that decides this is how much site cost actually disappears on closure, because unavoidable lease commitment would mean losing the revenue and keeping the cost.	K + AN + EV	The condition, expressed as the number to go and find.
6	If the leases are short, closure becomes defensible as part of a wider cost programme rather than instead of one.	EV	Second branch of the condition.
7	On the evidence available the answer is	EV	Restates the decision and converts it into an action.

	no, and the first action is a cost base review across all 120 sites.		
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Seven sentences. Two carry knowledge, three carry application, four carry analysis, seven carry evaluation, and none earn nothing. Show this one last. A class that only sees the long models concludes that the route to the top band is more words, and then runs out of time in the exam. What changed is density, not effort.

A mid band answer, annotated

#	The sentence	Tag	What it earns and why
1	There are many advantages and disadvantages to Verity Coffee closing its 20 weakest sites.	0	Restates the question. Earns nothing and costs a line. Cut it and start with the decision.
2	One advantage is that closing the sites would reduce costs, because the sites are making a loss.	K	True, and the term is used correctly, but there is no figure and no consequence. Nothing here is specific to Verity, so it fails the application test. The case gives £0.6 million, and using it would earn AP and AN as well.
3	This means the business would be more profitable and could invest the money elsewhere.	AN	A consequence, but a generic one. Invest the money elsewhere is true of any closure by any firm.
4	However, a disadvantage is that closing sites could damage the brand and upset customers.	K	Asserted, not developed and not tied to Verity. Nothing in the case suggests brand damage, so this is imported from a textbook.
5	Employees would also lose their jobs, which would affect motivation of remaining staff.	K + AN	A real chain, but again it would fit any business. No Verity evidence anywhere in it.
6	Closing sites is a big decision and the business would need to think carefully about it.	0	Filler. It advances nothing and it signals to the examiner that the writer has no view.
7	In conclusion, it depends on the situation of the business and what its objectives are.	0	The classic ending. It looks like evaluation and earns nothing, because no decision is made and no criterion is named.

The same answer, fixed

Sentence	What to do	What it becomes
Sentence 1	Delete it and open with the decision.	Verity should not close the 20 sites now.
Sentence 2	Add the figure from the case.	Closing them would remove a combined operating loss of £0.6 million.
Sentence 3	Replace the generic consequence with the one that matters.	But at £180,000 a site the closures cost £3.6 million, a six year payback on that £0.6 million.
Sentence 4	Cut the imported disadvantage and use one the case supports.	The larger doubt is whether these are the right sites at all.
Sentence 5	Keep the chain but tie it to Verity.	Revenue grew 9 per cent while operating profit fell nearly 40 per cent, so the problem is across all 120 sites.
Sentence 6	Delete it.	
Sentence 7	Replace it depends with the condition.	The answer is no unless the leases turn out to be short and genuinely exitable, in which case closure becomes part of a wider cost programme.

Seven sentences in, six out. One is deleted outright, one is replaced by the decision, three gain a figure from the case, and the ending becomes a condition. Nothing was added in length, and the answer moves bands. Do this live on the board rather than handing out the improved version, because the deletions are the part students find hardest to believe.

Lesson 1. What evaluation actually is

Objectives

1. Distinguish the four assessment objectives in a piece of writing.

2. Explain why balance is not the same as judgement.
3. Tag a short answer sentence by sentence and total the objectives.

Do Now

#	Question	Answer
1	What does AO4 stand for?	Evaluation. Judgement, weighing, conditions and supported decisions.
2	Give one phrase that looks like evaluation and earns nothing.	It depends. Both have advantages. In conclusion it is important to consider all factors.
3	What is the difference between analysis and evaluation?	Analysis follows a consequence through. Evaluation weighs it against something and decides.

Sequence

5 min. Do Now, three questions above.

10 min. The four objectives. One sentence each, then leave the table on the board for the whole unit.

10 min. Read the mid band answer without the annotation. Ask the class to mark it out of 25. Collect three numbers and write them up.

15 min. Reveal the annotation. Three of the seven sentences earn nothing. Work through why, slowly, especially the ending.

15 min. Students tag the mid band answer themselves using the key, then total by objective.

5 min. Close on the count. Three sentences of knowledge, two chains of analysis and no judgement at all is the shape of a mid band answer, and it is the shape most of them write.

You will need

The four objectives.

Tag key.

Mid band answer, one per student.

Teacher note

Do not show a strong model in this lesson. The lesson works because students first judge a weak answer generously and then see why they were wrong. Showing them excellence first removes that.

Lesson 2. Reading the annotation

Objectives

1. Identify which sentence in a strong answer carries the decisive judgement.
2. Explain why a sentence earns application rather than knowledge.
3. Write three evaluative sentences using shapes taken from the model.

Do Now

#	Question	Answer
1	What must a sentence contain to earn application?	Something specific to this business, its figures or its

		situation.
2	Why does a judgement need a number?	Without evidence it reads as a guess. The figure is what turns an opinion into a mark.
3	Where should the decision appear in an answer?	Early. An answer that decides at the end usually runs out of time and argues the other way first.

Sequence

5 min. Do Now.

18 min. The annotated model. Read it in order with the annotation covered, then reveal it a sentence at a time. Stop properly on sentence 7 and sentence 12.

8 min. Ask which single sentence, if deleted, would cost the most. Take votes. The answer is arguable, which is the point.

12 min. Model 2, same skill, other board, different question style. Read sentences 1 to 8 only and ask where the answer reaches a position.

12 min. Students write three evaluative sentences about Verity using three different shapes.

5 min. Read four aloud. Test each one against a single question: could this sentence appear in an answer about a different company?

You will need

Annotated model 1.

Annotated model 2.

The twelve shapes.

Case and figures.

Teacher note

The temptation is to move fast because the annotation is already written. Do not. The value is in stopping on individual sentences and asking why that tag and not the one next to it.

Lesson 3. Improving a mid band answer, live

Objectives

1. Identify the sentences in a mid band answer that earn nothing.
2. Rewrite a generic point so that it uses evidence from the case.
3. Replace a summary ending with a condition.

Do Now

#	Question	Answer
1	Name two things that make a sentence earn nothing.	Restating the question, or being true of any business anywhere.
2	What is wrong with ending on it depends?	No decision and no criterion, so nothing is being weighed.
3	What does a condition sentence do?	Names what would change the decision, which shows the judgement was reasoned.

Sequence

5 min. Do Now.

18 min. Rewrite the mid band answer on the board with the class, one sentence at a time, using the fixes. Delete a sentence in front of them and let the discomfort happen.

7 min. Now show the short model. Seven sentences, same band as the eighteen sentence version. This is the moment the length argument dies, and it only works after they have watched you delete.

15 min. Students take their own most recent essay and tag it sentence by sentence, then count by objective.

12 min. Each student rewrites four sentences of their own work: delete one, add a figure to two, replace the ending with a condition.

3 min. Close. The count before and the count after, on the board, from two volunteers.

You will need

Mid band answer.

The fixes.

The short model.

Students' own marked essays.

Teacher note

Deleting sentences in front of a class is the part they remember, because every student believes that more writing is safer. Show them it is not, then show them the short model while the point is still fresh.

Lesson 4. Timed practice and tagged peer marking

Objectives

1. Plan and write a timed evaluative answer using the five step method.
2. Tag a peer's answer objective by objective.
3. Give one specific improvement rather than a general comment.

Do Now

#	Question	Answer
1	State the five steps of the method from memory.	Decide first. Pick the criterion. Build the strongest opposing case. Weigh with a number. Attach the condition.
2	How early should the decision appear?	In the first few sentences.
3	What is the last sentence of a strong answer?	The condition, or the action that follows from the decision.

Sequence

5 min. Do Now, books closed.

5 min. Plan only, using the frame. Students write their one sentence answer and name their criterion.

30 min. Timed writing. Silence.

12 min. Swap. Tag the answer sentence by sentence with the key, total by objective, and write one specific improvement.

8 min. Two answers read out, tags compared. Ask which had the higher evaluation count and whether it was the better answer, because sometimes it is not.

You will need

Timed question.

Tag key.

Peer marking sheet.

Teacher note

If the evaluation count across the class is still under three sentences per answer, do not move on to new content. Re-run Lesson 3 with a different essay. The skill does not transfer from one exposure.

The twelve shapes an evaluative sentence takes

Type	The shape	What it does
Weighing	The stronger objection is not X, it is Y, because...	Ranks two arguments instead of listing them.
Weighing	This matters more in Verity's position than it would normally, because...	Makes the weight specific to the business.
Magnitude	A payback of six years is long relative to...	Turns a number into a judgement by comparing it to something.
Magnitude	This is a small effect next to the £X the business is losing on...	Puts a point in proportion, which is evaluation, not analysis.
Criterion	If the objective is protecting cash rather than lifting margin, then...	Names the criterion, which is what better or worse is measured against.
Concession	The case for X is strongest when..., and that condition does not hold here because...	Rejects a strong version of the counter argument.
Reframe	The question assumes the problem is X, but the evidence points to Y.	Challenges the premise, which is a top band move when the evidence supports it.
Evidence quality	The trial figures overstate this, because...	Interrogates the data rather than accepting it.
Condition	This decision changes entirely if...	One of the most reliable moves available, and one of the least used.
Condition	The number that settles this is..., and the business does not yet have it.	Names what would resolve the uncertainty.
Timing	This is the right action but the wrong moment, because...	Separates the decision from its timing, which most answers never do.
Decision	On the evidence available the answer is no, and the first step is...	Decides and converts the decision into an action.

These are not sentence starters to memorise and sprinkle. They are the twelve shapes an evaluative sentence takes.

Give students the list, then ask them to find each shape across the three annotated models. Almost all of them appear, and the one or two that do not are worth discussing: what would it take to use them on this case?

Timed practice

Verity Coffee is considering raising prices by 6 per cent across its range in order to restore its operating margin. Evaluate this decision. (20 marks)

	Write it here
My answer in one sentence	
The criterion I am judging against	

The strongest argument against me	
The figure I will weigh with	
What would change my mind	

Thirty minutes of writing. Use the figures. A strong answer will notice that a 6 per cent price rise on £96 million of revenue is worth about £5.8 million if volume holds, which is more than the entire current operating profit, and will then ask what happens to volume in a market where the competing product is fifty metres away. The best answers will reach for the margin history rather than treating the decision in isolation.

Tagged peer marking

	Answer
Total sentences	
Sentences tagged EV	
Sentences tagged 0	
Decision made by sentence number	
Criterion named? Which one?	
Condition present? Quote it.	
One specific improvement, naming a sentence number	

Specific means naming a sentence. Add a figure to sentence 4 is feedback. Add more evaluation is not, and it is what students write when they have not read the answer properly.

The fourteen errors that cost the most

Error	What it looks like	The fix
Balance mistaken for judgement	Two sides presented, no decision made.	Require a decision in the first five sentences, before any argument.
Judgement with no evidence	A confident conclusion with nothing behind it.	Every judgement sentence must sit next to a figure, a comparison or a piece of case evidence.
Evaluating the theory	Weighing the usefulness of a model instead of the decision facing the firm.	Ask: is this sentence about the business or about the textbook?
Generic points	A paragraph that would fit any company.	The paste test. Would it survive being pasted into an answer about a different firm?
Evaluation saved for the end	One evaluative paragraph after four descriptive ones.	Weigh as you go. The final paragraph should confirm the decision, not introduce it.
Beating a weak opponent	The counter argument is stated feebly so it is easy to reject.	Write the other side at its strongest first, then reject it.
No criterion	Better and worse used without saying better for what.	Name the objective in the opening paragraph and measure against it.
Numbers described, not used	A figure quoted and then left alone.	Every figure must be followed by a therefore.
Restating the question	The opening line repeats the question in different words.	Delete it. Open with the decision.
Announcing the essay	In this essay I will discuss the advantages and disadvantages.	Delete it. It costs a line and earns nothing.
Length as strategy	Writing more in the hope that judgement appears by accident.	Show the short model. Same band, well under half the words.
Hedging the decision	It could be argued either way depending on circumstances.	A decision with a condition attached is not a hedge. A decision avoided is.
Ignoring timing	Treating a decision as permanent when the question is about now.	Add now or yet to the decision sentence and see whether it changes.
Missing the condition	The answer decides and stops.	One sentence: what would change my mind. It is the cheapest mark available.

Weak and strong, the same point

What students write	What earns
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Closing stores would reduce costs.	Closing the 20 sites removes £0.6 million of losses but costs £3.6 million to execute.
This could damage the brand.	Verity has no evidence of brand strength in the case, so brand damage is asserted rather than argued.
The business should consider its objectives.	If the objective is cash preservation, a £3.6 million outflow to save £0.6 million a year fails on its own terms.
Margin would improve.	Margin rises from 5.0 to about 6.3 per cent, partly because revenue falls, which flatters the ratio.
Subscriptions could increase loyalty.	Subscribers visited 11 times a month against 6, so the loyalty effect is measurable rather than assumed.
There are risks with this strategy.	The risk is specific: 2.2 extra food purchases per subscriber per month are needed simply to stand still.
It depends on the economy.	A price rise of 6 per cent is worth about £5.8 million if volume holds, so the decision rests largely on the price elasticity of demand for coffee on a high street.
In conclusion, both options have merit.	On the evidence available the answer is no, and the first step is a cost base review across all 120 sites.
Employees may be demotivated.	Closing 20 of 120 sites tells the staff in the other 100 that the estate is shrinking, at the same moment the business needs them to sell more food per visit.
This is a difficult decision for managers.	The decision is difficult only because one number is missing, which is how much site cost actually disappears on closure.

Ten things to do in every evaluative answer

#	Do this
1	Decide in the first five sentences. An answer that decides at the end usually argued the other way first and then ran out of time.
2	Say better for what. Better and worse mean nothing until you name what the business is trying to do.
3	Put the other side at its strongest before you reject it. Beating a weak argument earns almost nothing.
4	Every judgement needs a number, a comparison or a piece of evidence sitting next to it.
5	Use the figures you are given. A figure quoted and then abandoned earns less than a figure followed by a therefore.
6	Weigh as you go. Evaluation is a way of writing sentences, not a paragraph at the end.
7	Cut the opening line that restates the question, and cut the line that announces what your essay will do. Both earn nothing.
8	Short sentences carry judgement perfectly well. Some of the strongest lines in a top band answer are under twenty words.
9	Length is not the variable. A seven sentence answer can reach the same band as an eighteen sentence one.
10	Finish with the condition. What would change your mind, in one sentence. Most students never write it, and it is the cheapest mark available.

Before Lesson 1

#	Do this	Why
1	Print the mid band answer for every student, and nothing else yet.	Lesson 1 depends on students marking a weak answer generously before they see the annotation.
2	Do not hand out a strong model in Lesson 1.	The sequence only works if the weak answer comes first.
3	Read Model 1 before you teach Lesson 2.	You will stop in the right places if you already know which sentence carries the answer.
4	Check level descriptors against your current mark scheme.	This pack teaches what a sentence must do. Your board decides how it is banded.

The editable Word version is included in this download. Change anything you like. It is your classroom.

New packs land in the free teacher group before they go anywhere else.

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